

Racially Motivated Violence Over Time: Patterns & Distribution

My project examined the relationship between early patterns of extralegal collective violence in the United States and later forms of violence, with a focus on how both regional distribution and underlying motivations shape long-term outcomes. Using both historical and modern datasets, I analyzed incidents of extralegal violence from 1783–1865, compared them to regional violent crime rates in 1977, and incorporated data on police shootings involving unarmed Black individuals to symbolize contemporary racialized violence. This approach allowed for both quantitative and interpretive analysis across time. The central research question guiding this project reads as follows: How do the regional distribution and motivations of extralegal collective violence from 1783–1865 relate to later patterns of violent crime and potential racialized violence in the United States?

The initial findings revealed a surprising geographic pattern. Between 1783 and 1865, the West, not the South, had the highest number of extralegal violence incidents, including racially motivated ones. The West also recorded the highest rate of extralegal violence in 1850. However, by 1977, the South had the highest violent crime rate, indicating a clear shift in the concentration of violence over time. This disparity proves that the frequency of violence does not determine long-term regional patterns, encouraging me to examine the conditions and motivations that produced violence in each region.

In the West, high levels of extralegal violence can likely be explained by frontier conditions, including rapid expansion, weak legal systems, and competition over land and resources. Violence in this setting was usually situational, used as a means to resolve disputes or assert control in the absence of formal authority. Even racially motivated violence was caused by these unstable conditions, particularly in conflicts involving Indigenous locals, Hispanic

populations, and other marginalized groups. The Gold Rush (1848) also drew extensive Asian immigrants to the region throughout the 1850s. Because this violence was tied to temporary instability rather than an already entrenched social system, it declined as the region became more settled and governed. This helps explain why the West's early prominence in violence did not persist into the modern period.

In contrast, extralegal violence in the South, although lower in overall frequency from 1783-1865, was more consistently tied to race and the institution of slavery. Slavery functioned as a deeply embedded social and legal structure that normalized racial hierarchy and control. Extralegal violence in this region was often used to enforce that hierarchy, making it systemic rather than situational. After the Civil War, these social structures did not disappear but instead evolved into new forms, such as segregation laws and various discriminatory policies (Sharecropping, Jim Crow, etc). By 1977, the South had the highest violent crime rates, which may be explained by a combination of economic inequality, uneven urban development, as well as the continuation of discriminatory policies that forced marginalized African Americans into concentrated areas of poverty. The areas had reduced access to quality education, employment opportunities, and public resources, shaping broader patterns of social and economic instability that can be associated with higher rates of violent crime. Furthermore, modern data showing a concentration of police shootings involving unarmed Black individuals in the South suggests that racialized violence may have shifted from extralegal to institutional forms, maintaining the same underlying dynamics of control. While the executors of violence have changed, the logic behind the killings remains the same.

In the South specifically, racialized police violence can be looked at as a result of the region's longer continuity of racialized social and political structures compared to the West

following slavery. After Reconstruction, systems such as Jim Crow laws, voter suppression, and racially segregated schooling and housing reinforced economic inequality in ways that remained more deeply established in the South than in all other regions. These patterns affected residential locations, resource allocation, and community surveillance, which then in turn influenced where police presence was most heavily concentrated. As a result, contemporary disparities in police violence may reflect historical issues that continue to shape exposure to law enforcement in the region.

A key takeaway of this project is that regional distribution or geographic prevalence is not a reliable predictor of long-term patterns of violence. While the West had the highest levels of extralegal violence in the historical period, this did not translate into higher modern violent crime rates. The findings of my study suggest that the type of violence, or its underlying motivation, plays a much more significant role in shaping long-term outcomes than sheer frequency. As previously explained, racially motivated violence in the West was often tied to shifting frontier dynamics and conflicts that diminished over time. In contrast, the South's violence was consistently rooted in maintaining a rigid racial hierarchy, allowing it to survive across generations. This explains why the South, despite lower historical rates, shows stronger continuity in both modern violent crime and potential racialized police brutality. Overall, my findings demonstrate that violence ingrained in stable systems of power is more likely to persist than violence produced by temporary conditions.

However, it is important to acknowledge the many limitations of this analysis. The datasets used in this project vary in structure and scope, making direct comparisons extremely difficult. Extralegal violence in the nineteenth century is not necessarily equivalent to modern violent crime or police shootings, and each dataset reflects different forms of reporting, bias, and

categorization. Nowhere near the complete number of extralegal killings that actually occurred were recorded in the specific dataset I used, making my sample size very limited, and the broad time range (1783-1863) makes it hard, if not impossible, to account for shifting social norms, significant historical events, or changing governmental policies that would have affected the rates of extralegal violence. Certain regions could be vastly overrepresented compared to others due to better recording practices, or descriptions of the killings could be distorted because of historical bias. Additionally, using police shootings of unarmed Black individuals as a proxy for racially motivated violence introduces interpretive challenges, as not all cases can be definitively attributed to racial bias. However, despite these limitations, the regional patterns that emerge across multiple datasets prove that the findings are not purely coincidental.

Ultimately, this project demonstrates that long-term patterns of violence in the United States are shaped less by where violence was most frequent and more by the systems and motivations that produce it. The shift from the West to the South as the primary site of violence highlights how geography alone cannot explain continuity. Instead, the persistence of racialized violence in the South suggests that deeply rooted social and institutional systems continue to influence present-day outcomes. By focusing on both distribution and motivation, this analysis provides a more nuanced understanding of how historical violence evolves and why certain patterns endure over time.